

Total Guitar

Maverick Species-1

PLUS! Maverick X-1, F-1 and Nemesis S-4

This guitar is a wholly different kettle of fish, a fact that's perceptible straight away: compared to the F-3, it's as light as an astronaut's feather boa. It weighs in at over a kilo less than its sibling even though its body is of the same dimensions. The reason is the Species 1's body is fashioned from basswood, a much lighter material than alder, and the cool sculpting here is among the model's specific new features.

Other new features include the provision of the same pickups as used on Maverick's shapely X-1 model: a pair of LQ-6 Custom 'buckers. Uncovered and bristling with oversized Alnico rod pole-pieces, their design allows for the strings to vibrate in a nicely wide magnetic field thus giving a more consistent output. This is especially useful given that the guitar is surely designed for modern metal styles, what with the thru-body stringing and so on, and Maverick string the guitar with a set of .010-.052 GHS wires. Obviously this heavy gauge of bass string allows for a vastly increased stability at lower pitches and we applaud the fact that the company has clearly given so much thought to this guitar.

A single piece of maple also makes up the neck and, although it's glued-in rather than bolted, the ivoroid's vintage colouring is even more attractive than on the F-3. Maverick has used a slightly lower grade of rosewood for the 'board and, with respect to our friends in Ontario, California, the feel of the neck as a whole is not too far removed from one of Jackson's sumptuous Custom Shop Dinkys. High praise certainly, but such is the smooth feel and the quality of the fretwork it almost plays itself and that's no mean feat at this price.

It's difficult to see, even in our hi-resolution shots of the guitar, but there are flecks of a metallic material hidden in the depths of the Cosmos black finish; under stage lights, this thing will shimmer like an axe possessed.

As we've suggested, the blend of basswood with hot pickups is practically the defining rock tone of the last 15 years and, with offensive levels of distortion dialled in to our Boogie Recto 60 combo, the airy yet forceful tone is a joy to play with.

Our opinions of the F-3's neck humbucker don't need repeating as the unit here can either jazz it up with a clean setting or cause an involuntary bowel movement from nearby animals with an amp set to stun. Either way, its tone stands well apart from the bridge unit, while positions two, three and four on the lever selector gives tones that could be Tele or SG in origin.

In short, the Species 1 will rock your world with ease, but will also stay with you if you need it to be restrained.

The Species 1 is a doozy of a guitar, with the price, look, feel and performance to surely appeal to virtually all players of modern rock and metal styles. The heavier string gauge is a simple yet clever idea that will allow for easy downtuning of the low E out of the box, and the hot pickups are balanced efficiently by the spacious tonal nature of the basswood body. We know by now that a double-locking vibrato is no longer a necessary requirement of a hard rocking guitar these days: all you need is a solid instrument like the Species 1.

We admire the whole ideal behind Maverick guitars, an English name taking on the big boys in an already crowded market and certainly holding their own. The changes in spec made to the 2004 range are all beneficiary, thus re-lifting the brand to its previous position of a 'must check out' ideal for rock players.

★★★★★ Guitarist magazine, Summer 2004

GEAR MAVERICK X-1



Maverick's own LQ-6 humbuckers supply unbelievable low-end punch

X1's floating tremolo prevents tuning slippage during whammy bar abuse

£499

MAVERICK X-1

LOOKING FOR AN AXE TO GRIND? MEET THE MAVERICK X-1... WORDS: HENRY YATES

> Better lock up your daughters...

Bit of a beast, isn't it? In fact, when Maverick's X-1 turned up at *TG* Towers, our first instinct was to chain it to a wooden stake and bait it with wild dogs, before anointing the damn thing in holy water. This guitar radiates evil. From the apocalyptic paint job to that needle-sharp headstock, *TG* hasn't felt such a humming of malevolence since the in-laws dropped round.

The body lines appear to be the product of a rhino and a Gibson Explorer locked up together in a hotel suite with *Saxophone Moods* and a plate of oysters – even the pickup selector could puncture your spleen. In a market where drawing round the outline of a Strat passes as design, the X-1 sets Satan's stall out in style.

Who are these Maverick fellas, anyway?

The brand might not have the dusty heritage of Fender and the gang, but since Maverick's birth in 1997, this relative newcomer has earned a great reputation for its electric models. Hand-made in Korea (but designed in England), Maverick guitars have always combined attitude and innovation with keen pricing, making them some of the only Far Eastern axes that wouldn't be laughed out of a recording studio. Huge sounds, high output humbuckers and superior build are all Maverick's calling cards – and we're told that the X-1 ain't about to mess with the formula.

It looks pretty original...

You said it. Satanic undercurrents aside, there's evidence a few drawing boards went into the X-1's design. Perhaps the most

obvious feature is this guitar's reverse body and headstock, which prompted some head-shaking around the *TG* office. See, aside from the icon factor, there's a good reason why most firms lean towards a Strat-style body. It's bloody comfortable, for one thing, plus you can play it while slouching on the sofa. By contrast, we've lost count of the amount of guitar exotica to slide off our laps into obscurity, making us concerned the X-1's show-stealing spikes might actually stab it in the foot. To its credit, Maverick has realised this could be an issue, and assure us this design gives a balance of weight, whether you're standing, sitting or slouching. Does it work? We'll let you know...

It has a lot of frets...

We're surprised you didn't lose count. Whereas your basic Telecaster has a meagre

22 frets, the Maverick X-1 boasts a whopping 24 lined up on its rosewood fingerboard. Better still, the cutaways we had written off as a design flourish actually enable meaningful technique along the length of the X-1's bolt-in maple neck.

If that implies a guitar built for technique, then a glance at the X-1's bridge confirms it. Since hair metal's peak in the 80s, every thrash axe worth its salt has featured a locking tremolo unit inspired by the Floyd Rose design, and Maverick's X-1 is no exception. As a principle, it's simple; by clamping the strings in place at the nut and bridge, you avoid the tuning slippage that can occur after whammy abuse and frenzied spanking. In practice, you'll probably want help setting it up, but once in position, it shouldn't take more than the occasional tweak of the bridge tuners to keep your



HUMBUCKING THE TREND

MAVERICK'S QUEST FOR THE PERFECT PICK-UP

Maverick's Mark James is a man on a mission. His objective: to create the world's finest humbucker, rewrite the pickup rule book, then stand astride the electric guitar industry like a colossus. And with the devastating LQ-6 items featured on Maverick's X-1, we reckon he might just have managed it.

Following brief collaborations with Duncan and DiMarzio, Mark decided he wanted his axes to feature exclusively Maverick electronics, so he hooked up with guitar design guru Ray Wilkinson back in 1999 to work on the LQ-6 items. "Without giving away too many of our trade secrets," explains Mark, "these are tightly hand-wound units that use a ceramic magnetic base, coupled via 6mm soft iron pole-pieces. By carefully matching high-quality custom copper windings to a very specific bobbin size, we were able to produce a high output humbucker that retained a really open and spacious

character. With the X-1, we've also managed to get total separation between switchings. That's sometimes more easily said than done, especially on a 24-fret guitar, where the pickups are forced much closer together."

The results are obvious; the X-1 sounds huge, produces effortless output and lends a brutal swagger to the most rudimentary of chord sequences. "Well, we tested it against all the pickups we could get our hands on," Mark recalls. "As you know, the acid test is purely the sound, and live is where any weakness shows. There are several bands on the bill at this year's Download who've swapped in our humbuckers."

And with coil-splittable humbuckers to be available from Maverick soon, Mark has his work cut out: "There have been a few late nights, but me and Trevor don't care. We're like two kids, we still just love playing the guitar." Funny, sounds strangely familiar to *TG*...



24 frets line up on X1's rosewood fretboard – plenty of room for technique

The Evolution roller system allows adjustment of master tone and volume via two controls



thunderous racket at the right pitch. Useless with the pliers? Don't sweat it, there's a fixed bridge version available too.

How about the electronics?

Ah yes, the best bit. An electric guitar is only as good as its pickups – and, boy, has Maverick delivered the goods here. A pair of the company's own custom LQ-6 humbuckers supply the grunt, with a traditional three-way pickup selector offering the choice of neck, bridge or both. We liked these units so much we've picked the brain of the man behind them (see panel, below left) – suffice to say the guiding principles are filth, output and extended harmonics.

Browsers and girlfriends, meanwhile, will doubtless make a beeline for the X-1's two quirky control dials. This is Maverick's patented Evolution roller system, letting you adjust the X-1's master tone and volume via a pair of revolving dials set into the basswood body. Like gull-wing doors or breast implants, we'd suggest these are

more about aesthetics than a real advance on existing control knobs, but they do the job with minimal fuss and add to the vibe, so you won't catch us complaining.

That's the theory – give it a try...

Compared to the innumerable Strat-o-likes that pass through TG's hands each week, rocking out with the X-1 initially felt unnatural. Stick with it, though, as once you get used to it this axe plays like an extension of your arm. Admittedly, the X-1 does feel massive against the body – and you'll notice those two extra frets – but it isn't at the expense of fingerboard control, and the weight is nowhere near on a par with a Les Paul. True to Maverick's claims, that oddball body shape doesn't compromise posture or handling either, and it's equally feasible to spank this guitar while performing scissor-kicks or sat in an armchair.

So far, so good, but the real test of the X-1's speed-metal aspirations hinges on its neck and fretboard. Without your fingers

WHO'S IT FOR?

Tone-conscious thrashers, mid-price metallers and horsemen of the apocalypse

INFORMATION

ORIGIN: Korea
BODY: Solid basswood
NECK: US maple, bolt-in, one-piece, C/D profile
FINGERBOARD: AAA Indian rosewood
FRETS: 24
PICKUPS: Two LQ-6 custom humbuckers
CONTROLS: Evolution roller system master tone and volume
HARDWARE: Maverick-branded machineheads, Floyd Rose tremolo (optional)
CASE: No
COLOURS: Cosmos black, Lunar blue
LEFT-HANDERS: No
CONTACT: www.maverickguitars.com

feeling comfortable on a smooth-playing neck shape, lightning-fast legato would soon become a living hell, so we were relieved to find the Maverick delivered in spades. Thanks to a shallow neck profile and frets that slide effortlessly beneath the fingertips, we found bends, stretches and extravagant top fret squealies well catered for. Are you more of a ham-fisted barre chorder? Well, you won't go wrong here either.

Let's talk tone...

It's enormous. Of course, you'd expect low-end punch from any decent humbucker, but these twin LQ-6 pickups lend a depth and weight to the sound that blew us away. It's the kind of high-output tone that fills a room; warm without being soupy, always desperate to distort, and equally suited to searing lead work when you switch to the bridge position. Filth aside, the clean channel revealed a surprisingly distinguished voice – warm, authoritative and viable for any genre you throw at it.

Worth sticking up the post office for?

Too right, it is. The Maverick X-1 is a guitar of rare quality – and another reason why the US big guns can't afford to rest on their laurels. True, £500 is an investment, but we think it's pretty reasonable for one of the best rock axes TG has played in years. Our verdict? X definitely hits the spot.

FOR: Flawless build; ballsy tone; mental styling

AGAINST: Body shape takes a little bit of getting used to...

TG RATING:



The sculpted heel and recessed neck bolts allow good access to the upper frets